The Importance of Theory of Knowledge

Muhammad Gaffar[1]
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Abstract: I express the importance of theory of knowledge (epistemology) as acquisition and justification of belief systems. This essay emphasizes the significance of epistemology as a foundational tool for understanding the limitations of knowledge, and how to navigate the abundance of information and knowledge in the modern world. Epistemological inquiry is path of humility, yet path to the truth.

"I think I am right"

Bob and Sarah

Bob: I think I've been cursed by my neighbor; I believe she is a witch. Last month, we had a disagreement about whether this particular garden in our area is mine or hers. Since then, she has hated me. I've been hearing weird sounds in my home at midnight, the light bulb suddenly turns off, the door opens suddenly, and even my tap water becomes dirty and reddish. Sometimes, my stomach hurts so much, but my doctor tells me there's nothing wrong with me. I know she is using witchcraft to curse me.

Sarah: Come on, Bob, this is the twenty-first century. We all know such things don't work. Even if your neighbour thought she was casting a spell on you, which I'm sure she didn't, that obviously had nothing to do with the real cause of your misery. There will be a perfectly natural scientific explanation of why that's the case.

Bob: You haven't actually got a scientific explanation; you've just asserted there is one.

Sarah: That's unfair! You don't expect all the scientific resources of the Western world to be concentrated on explaining why your door open, do

[1] read online in *https://kfkq.github.io/*

you? I'm not being dogmatic, there's just no reason to doubt that a scientific explanation could in principle be given.

Bob: You expect me to take that on faith? You don't always know best, you know. I'm actually giving you an explanation. (Mustn't talk too loudly.) My neighbour's a witch. Even if you had your precious scientific explanation with deterministic of atoms and molecules, it would only be technical details. It would give no reason why things happened at me suddenly. The only explanation that makes real sense of it is witchcraft. Who knows how witchcraft works? Whatever it does, that her hatred in past month explains why the weird things happen to me lately.

Sarah: I can't believe I'm having this conversation. Do you seriously deny that scientific journals are full of evidence for modern scientific theories? Isn't all of that evidence against witchcraft?

Bob: How do we know how much of that so-called evidence is genuine? There have been lots of scandals recently about scientists faking their results. For all we know, the ones who get caught are only the tip of the iceberg.

Sarah: Well, if you prefer, look at all the successful technology around you. You're sitting on a train, and I notice you have a laptop and a mobile phone. Think of all the science that went into them. You're not telling me they work by witchcraft, are you?

Bob: Lots of modern science and technology is fine in its own way. When my I got stomache, I went to hospital by ambulance, not broom, thank goodness. None of that means modern science can explain everything.

Sarah: If all that modern science is fine in its own way, isn't the evidence for it evidence against witchcraft, just as I said?

Bob: I don't see why. You seem to think modern science implies witchcraft doesn't work. Why are you so sure? As far as I know, those scientific theories of yours don't say anything directly about witches, for or against. For that matter, they don't say anything directly about politicians either, for or against. That doesn't mean modern science

implies political propaganda doesn't work. Why is it any different for witchcraft?

Sarah: But isn't witchcraft supposed to involve forces unknown to modern science that would interfere with its predictions?

Bob: They may be unknown to modern science, but does modern science claim to know everything? Witchcraft may even work in accordance with the laws of science, using them for its own ends. Perhaps witchcraft helps make science's predictions come true.

Sarah: In principle maybe that can't be ruled out yet, but in practice, if witchcraft really worked, shouldn't we have better evidence of it by now? For instance, wouldn't some witches give in to the temptation to make a fortune by successfully performing witchcraft on television? Think of the viewing figures when it is announced that a famous personality will be turned into a frog on a live broadcast tonight!

Bob: Even if a witch did that, most people would think it was just some sort of trick. To be honest, I'm not sure witchcraft would work in such conditions. The magic may require a big sacrifice. It's not meant for everyone.

Sarah: How convenient. You keep explaining away the shortage of evidence for witchcraft. Let's put it this way. There is massive evidence in favour of modern science. There is no serious evidence in favour of witchcraft.

Bob: Simplicity isn't truth. You're right, lots of so-called witches are not real witches. Maybe most of them. But that doesn't mean there are no genuine witches. Too wise to say they're wise. Too much has happened to me I know to explain except by witchcraft. When I look at all that evidence, it's pretty obvious, there are real witches.

Sarah: Is it only witchcraft, or do you believe in all sorts of other superstitions as well?

Bob: 'Superstition'! I know about witchcraft from my own personal experiences of it, not just from what other people tell me or I read in books.

About things I haven't experienced, I don't know, and try to be open-minded.

Bob: 'Open-minded'! You just interpret your experiences in terms of your preconceived ideas. You twist the story of your door to suit your desire for a scapegoat to blame your misfortune on. It's pointless arguing with you. Nothing will shake your faith in witchcraft!

Bob: Will anything shake your faith in modern science?

Notes: This dialogue is taken from the Tetralogue by Timothy Williamson[2] with slightly modification

Reflection on belief

Dialogue above represents two ends of the spectrum for examples's sake. The nuances reflected are applicable to various belief systems encountered in everyday life. We could switch the topic to discussions around things that we believe, such as liberalism versus socialism, capitalism versus communism, materialistic determinism versus transcendence, theism versus atheism, differences in rights and responsibilities between men and women, morality versus ethics, evolution versus design arguments, or even debates between quantum mechanics and general relativity.

The quest for truth across various belief systems prompts the question: can knowledge be attained solely through accumulation of information, and what constitutes the nature of that information? However, knowledge is not mere mere data collection and individuals are not walking encyclopedias. The principles of belief justification and the essence of knowledge itself must come into focus. Without a foundational principle in our approach to knowledge, justification often falls to fallacies, particularly circular reasoning. Exceptional individuals will incline towards skepticism often went into the theory of knowledge, known as Epistemology, to scrutinize the very basis of knowing.

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[2] Williamson, Timothy. _Tetralogue: I'm right, you're wrong_. Oxford University Press, USA, 2015.

I found Einstein quote lately[3], in 1916, in which he said,

> *.... When I think the ablest students whom I have encountered in teaching --i.e., those who distinguished themselves by their independence of judgment, and not only mere agility-- I find that they had a lively concern for the theory of knowledge. The like to start discussions concerning the aims and methods of the sciences, ...*
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> *.... Concepts which have proved useful for ordering things easily assume so great an authority over us, that we forget their terrestrial origin and accept them as unalterable facts. They then become labelled as 'conceptual necessities,' 'a priori situations,' etc. The road of scientific progress is frequently blocked for long periods for such errors.*

It seems excessive by some people to get into epistemology stuff, why can't we know like how we know our everyday life? It works, it's convenient, without understanding epistemology. I somehow agree we don't need know too much about epistemology about how to lace our shoes, how to calculate tax, how to run business, and so on. The importance epistemology will come to light when to disagreement on fundamental issues comes arises, either about nature like physical science, or basis of human agency, like morality and political-social system. Those disagreement will never be solved, unless we go back all the way to understand the nature of knowledge, how do we know at all and by what it is justified?

Importance of Epistemology on reasoning

The question of the nature of knowledge traces back to ancient times, finding roots in the classical Greece, notably evident in Plato's dialogues. Since then, a rich history of epistemological exploration has unfolded, with scholars across cultures and eras founding schools of thought dedicated to understanding knowledge. From renowned figures like Plato and Aristotle in ancient Greece to luminaries such as Ibn Sina (Avicenna), Ibn Taymiyyah, and Fakhr al-Din al-Razi in the Islamic Golden Age, and from Descartes, Hume, and Kant in the Enlightenment period to modern thinkers like Husserl and Wittgenstein, the quest to comprehend how

[3] Snipped from *The Mathematical Intelligencer. 12, 27–31 (1990)*

humans can apprehend reality has persisted. Across these diverse intellectual traditions, the fundamental question remains: How can we truly grasp the nature of reality and justify our understanding of it?

Understanding concept like epistemology early on is crucial for several reasons. Firstly, it serves as a foundational tool for recognizing the inherent limitations of knowledge acquisition. We gain insight into the assumptions of reasoning processes and know its limit within which area those assumptions can be effectively applied. This awareness is essential in a world where many individuals tend to overestimate their capacity for rationality, leading to the contradictions, ignorance, and injustice rooted in false beliefs clowning as truths.

Secondly, the significance of epistemology becomes increasingly apparent in the contemporary world characterized by the abundant of information and diverse knowledge sources. As we grow up in this globalized modern life, we are constantly bombarded with many influences—from our upbringing and education to the media we consume—all of which contribute to shaping our worldview. In this age, clashes of arguments are common, where what appears convincing may not necessarily align with objective truth. Without a foundational understanding of epistemology, we risk falling into the biases in our cognitive frameworks, undermining our ability to make judgments.

Finally, embracing epistemological step to know is a hallmark of intellectual humility and curiosity. By engaging in the ongoing battle against epistemic diseases—such as intellectual arrogance, bias, fallacies, and abusing authority—we will eventually get the deeper understanding of the complexities of knowledge. This journey requires not only a commitment to rationality but also a willingness to confront and acknowledge the hidden assumptions and methodological limitations that shape our cognitive frameworks.

Remember that majority of our knowledge are known by secondary sources, i.e by reading books, mass testimonies, or taught by society. Given the limited time and resources available, it's impractical to independently verify every statement we encounter; instead, we often place trust in

authorities on knowledge. However, it's essential to recognize the limitations of these authorities and understand the scope of their expertise. This entails grasping the underlying assumptions within their knowledge frameworks and how these assumptions are justified. For example, physical science reasoning has different assumptions from economic reasoning. Neuroscience has different assumptions from psychology. What is considered right in morality and ethical statements has a different approach compared to what is considered right in the context of culture, religion, and politics. Understanding and acquiring historical knowledge differs from acquiring knowledge through the scientific method, which relies on experimentation, and so on.

The complexity arises from the fact that our way of conducting our lives is entangled with various forms of knowledge, which cannot be easily separated. However, there is no single method of knowing and justifying all of them at once.

The starting point

I may not be a philosopher who deeply understands everything about the theory of knowledge and philosophy. However, as a starting point and approach to something we think we know, it's crucial to always ask good questions. There are no general rules for asking good questions, but they usually lead to answers that are not immediately apparent. When I say "not apparent," I mean that when you attempt to justify the answer based on basic knowledge, you find yourself confused and uncertain. This confusion often signifies a good question.

The second point to consider is the recognition that there are various types of knowledge, each requiring a unique approach for understanding. Attempting to approach different forms of knowledge in the same manner can quickly lead to fallacious conclusions. For example, it's erroneous to assume that the scientific method is universally applicable and that we can brute force it to understand across all domains. Often, what is observable merely presents a superficial correlation rather than a deeper comprehension of underlying causes. It's important to acknowledge that different approaches are necessary to truly grasp the nature of human agency, nature, society, jurisprudence, as well as religious and historical knowledge. Anyone claiming to understand life solely through a specific

method demonstrates arrogance and fails to recognize the inherent limitations, living a contradiction life.

For the sake of practicality, always start from the question, as it helps resolve disagreements and doubts within you. Even though, you will inevitably become more skeptical about certain ideas and develop more questions from studying various theories of knowledge that interest you. It's better to avoid blind trust and certainty with arrogance. Our beliefs (and certainty) should start from learning and doubts rather than from mere acceptance as they are. It shows our responsibility and justice toward ourself and the world around us.

It's might be useful to acknowledge the frequent confusions are from our assumptions about language. Understanding knowledge is inherently tied to how we use language. No matter how clear our perception about the the world, our experiences, mental concepts, and memories; knowledge ultimately finds expression through language[4]. Therefore, I believe it is beneficial to investigate language usage before scrutinizing specific theories of knowledge. Sometimes, confusion arises due to semantic nuances or misinterpretations within a particular context. Other times, figurative language complicates understanding, or statements may seem nonsensical due to being known only to the speaker. It's essential to consistently seek clarification in such instances.

Train yourself avoiding various forms of logical fallacies when inspecting or constructing arguments. It's important to familiarize yourself with the principles of logic, as it is inherently deductive and thus always true by definition. However, it's essential to be cautious, as the propositions contained within the deductive process may not always hold true.

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[4] Language is not simply a uttered words or written statements, but also body gesture, sign, or sounds to express something, though words and statement is much more precise to convey abstract concepts.